THE BLACKHEARTS

Advanced Combat, Injuries & Lethality

Blood, Coin, and Betrayal

I. Death, Dying & Exhaustion

Combat in The Blackhearts is exceptionally dangerous. Characters may survive terrible wounds, but repeated brushes with death will take their toll.

Reaching Zero or Negative Hit Points

Whenever a character is reduced to 0 HP or below and subsequently survives, they receive exhaustion according to the number of times they have been reduced to 0 or fewer HP within a seven-day period.

Occurrence within 7 days	Exhaustion gained	Cumulative exhaustion
First	1	1
Second	2	3
Third	3	6 — Death

These exhaustion levels accumulate. At six exhaustion levels, the character dies.

A character who is reduced to 0 or fewer HP three times within a single seven-day period will die from accumulated exhaustion, assuming no exhaustion has been removed in the interim.

The normal rules for removing exhaustion may affect the total, subject to the DM's ruling.

Unconsciousness at Exactly 0 HP

A character reduced to exactly 0 HP falls unconscious. They do not begin death throes and do not accumulate death counters simply from remaining unconscious. However, if they are revived or otherwise survive the incident, they still incur the appropriate exhaustion penalty.

Death Throes: Negative Hit Points

A character reduced below 0 HP enters death throes. Standard death saving throws are replaced with the following system:

• At the beginning of each of their turns, the character receives one death counter.

• Upon receiving their fourth death counter, the character dies.

• Every additional instance of damage suffered while in death throes immediately adds another death counter.

• Death throes continue until the character is stabilized, healed, or dies.

A character with negative HP is therefore in immediate danger, and further attacks can rapidly hasten their death.

II. Called Shots & Localized Injuries

Characters may deliberately target specific parts of an opponent's body to inflict localized injuries. Each body region possesses an injury threshold calculated as a percentage of the target's maximum HP. These thresholds do not represent separate HP pools. Instead, they determine when accumulated damage to a specific region may produce an injury.

Body Region Thresholds

Targeted region	Injury threshold	Attack penalty
Torso — chest, back, abdomen	40% of maximum HP	–1 to hit
Head — skull, face, neck	20% of maximum HP	–3 to hit
Limb — arm, leg, hand, foot	10% of maximum HP	–2 to hit

For example, a character with 50 maximum HP has a head injury threshold of 10 damage. If accumulated damage to the head reaches 10, an injury may occur. A further 10 damage to that region can trigger another injury.

Multiple Injuries

Injury thresholds may be reached multiple times on the same body region. Reaching a threshold does not necessarily incapacitate the affected body part. The nature and severity of an injury depend on the location struck, the weapon involved, and the circumstances of the attack.

Possible effects include bleeding, concussions, blindness, impaired movement, reduced attack or damage rolls, penalties to ability scores or saving throws, and other temporary or lasting impairments. The DM determines the specific injury using the appropriate injury rules.

III. Critical Successes & Failures

Critical results are considerably more dangerous in The Blackhearts than in conventional D&D. Whenever a natural 20 or natural 1 occurs on an attack roll, saving throw, ability check, or skill check, a d100 is rolled to determine the severity of the critical outcome. A natural 20 represents a critical success. A natural 1 represents a critical failure. Higher percentile results produce more severe effects.

Weapon Critical Successes

Grade	d100 result	Effect
Poor	1–25	1.5× damage
Fair	26–40	2× damage
Good	41–80	3× damage
Excellent	81–95	4× damage
Incredible	96–100	Instant death

An Incredible weapon critical is immediately fatal to the target. These multipliers replace the conventional critical damage calculation for weapon attacks.

Critical Failures

Critical failures use the same percentile grades, with consequences determined by the DM according to the action attempted. Possible outcomes include dropped weapons, damaged equipment, loss of footing, accidental injuries, exposure to enemy attacks, or more serious consequences. Critical successes and failures involving skills, saving throws, and other noncombat actions also follow this percentile system, with effects appropriate to the situation.

IV. Flanking

Flanking rewards coordinated positioning against an engaged opponent. A target is considered flanked when one enemy occupies and engages it from a 90-degree cone in front, while another occupies and engages it from a 90-degree cone behind.

Front Attacker

• Gains +2 to attack rolls against the flanked target.

• Gains +2 AC while maintaining the frontal engagement.

Rear Attacker

• Gains +2 to attack rolls against the flanked target.

• The flanked target loses any AC bonuses derived from Dexterity, Wisdom, or Constitution against the rear attacker.

Flanking remains in effect only while the necessary positioning and engagement are maintained.

V. Swarm Tactics

Swarm tactics occur when four or more combatants coordinate their attacks against a single target. When the conditions for swarming are met:

• The attackers receive a cumulative +2 bonus to grapple attempts.

• The attackers receive +2 to attack rolls.

• The surrounded target suffers disadvantage on Strength- and Dexterity-based saving throws and ability checks.

Combat tactics are cumulative. A target may be simultaneously flanked and swarmed, suffering the combined consequences of both situations.

Player-Created Tactics

Players are encouraged to create and describe their own combat tactics. A tactic may involve coordinated movement, specialized positioning, environmental interaction, feints, distractions, improvised maneuvers, or any other plan that fits the situation.

The DM determines whether a proposed tactic is possible and what requirements must be met. These requirements may include specific positioning, available equipment, successful ability checks, timing, communication, or cooperation between multiple characters.

If the tactic is clearly described and its requirements are satisfied, the DM may grant an appropriate bonus or other advantage. The reward may include a bonus to attack rolls, damage, AC, saving throws, ability checks, movement, or another benefit suited to the tactic.

The DM may also limit, modify, or deny a bonus when the tactic is unclear, impossible under the circumstances, or already fully represented by an existing combat rule. Creative tactics should reward preparation and teamwork without replacing sound judgment or the risks of combat.

Coordinated enemies are therefore considerably more dangerous than isolated opponents, even when individually weaker.

VI. Elevation & Range

Terrain and relative elevation have a significant impact on combat effectiveness.

Melee Combat: Higher Ground

A combatant fighting from higher ground receives +2 to attack rolls against a lower opponent. The lower combatant suffers –2 to attack rolls against the elevated opponent. These modifiers apply when the DM determines that the height difference provides a meaningful tactical advantage.

Ranged Combat: Elevation

Elevation difference	Firing downward	Firing upward
10–19 feet	+1 hit / +1 damage	–1 hit / –1 damage
20–29 feet	+2 hit / +2 damage	–2 hit / –2 damage
30 feet or more	+3 hit / +3 damage	–3 hit / –3 damage

The maximum elevation modifier is +3/+3 or –3/–3.

Firing into Melee

Ranged attacks directed into an ongoing melee carry a risk of striking an unintended combatant. Each shot fired into melee has a **25% chance of striking an unintended target**. This risk reflects the unpredictable movements of combatants during close fighting. Certain feats and called-shot techniques may negate this risk.

VII. Surprise Attacks

A combatant who successfully attacks an unaware opponent before initiative has been rolled receives a devastating advantage. A qualifying surprise attack:

• Automatically hits the target.

• Inflicts maximum normal weapon damage.

• Still requires an attack roll to determine whether a natural 20 or natural 1 occurs.

If the roll produces a critical result, the appropriate percentile critical rules apply. Surprise attacks can be particularly deadly when combined with powerful weapons, careful positioning, and coordinated planning.

VIII. Bleeding

Bleeding is a dangerous, cumulative condition representing a serious wound that causes persistent blood loss. Ordinary cuts, scrapes, and superficial bleeding do not automatically qualify.

Bleeding Damage

Each instance of bleeding causes 1d4 damage at the beginning of the affected combatant's turn. Multiple instances stack.

Active bleeding instances	Damage per turn
1	1d4
2	2d4
3	3d4
4	4d4
5	5d4

Bleeding continues until successfully treated or otherwise stopped.

Stopping Bleeding

A character may attempt to stop bleeding by succeeding on an appropriate Medicine check. The difficulty increases with the number of active bleeding instances. The DM determines the required DC according to the severity and complexity of the wounds. Bleeding can rapidly become fatal, particularly when multiple injuries are sustained in a short period.

IX. Defensive Reactions: Blocking, Parrying & Dodging

Characters who are aware of an incoming attack may attempt an active defensive maneuver. A combatant must declare the defensive reaction and roll a d20, adding the appropriate ability modifier. The result is compared against the attacker's hit roll.

If the defender's result exceeds the attacker's result, the incoming attack is successfully avoided or deflected.

The available maneuvers depend upon the defender's equipment.

Blocking

Requires an equipped shield.

• Uses Strength modifier.

• Represents intercepting an attack with the shield.

• May cause durability damage to the shield.

Parrying

Requires a weapon capable of parrying.

• Uses Dexterity modifier.

• Represents deflecting or redirecting an incoming attack with a weapon.

• May cause durability damage to the parrying weapon.

Dodging

Requires light armor or no armor.

• Uses Dexterity modifier.

• Represents avoiding the incoming attack through movement and positioning.

• Does not ordinarily involve equipment durability damage.

All defensive maneuvers require the defender to be aware of the attack. The normal limitations on available reactions apply unless another ability or rule states otherwise.

X. Tactical Combat & Survival

The advanced combat rules are designed to reward preparation, positioning, coordination, creative tactics, and intelligent decision-making.

A heavily armored warrior may be overwhelmed by several coordinated opponents. A skilled swordsman may suffer a devastating injury from a well-placed attack. An archer occupying elevated terrain may control a battlefield, while an unsuspecting guard can be killed before drawing his weapon.

Equipment quality, durability, terrain, and the condition of combatants all influence survival.

Players should consider not only how to defeat their opponents, but also how to avoid exposing themselves to unnecessary risks. They are encouraged to communicate, plan, and propose tactics that take advantage of the battlefield and the tools available to them.

In The Blackhearts, combat is not a contest of who can endure the most punishment. It is a contest of who can inflict decisive harm while avoiding it themselves.

Steel breaks. Flesh tears. Blood spills.

And the dead do not collect their pay.